were Swadeshi steamers. *The Hindu* also exposed the sneaky claim of BI that it was an Indian firm as it was contributing to the Indian Famine Fund! In such claims, it noted 'a tone of despair' and said that 'is our hope'.[71]

Such was the popular antipathy towards BI that when the boiler of one of its steamers burst, the nationalist press rejoiced that its passengers—including some European ladies and gentlemen—took the chartered Swadeshi steamer, the *Ipswich*.[72] Occasions for such minor victories were few and far between.

In this situation, an atmosphere of fear prevailed that militated against people investing in SSNCo. As the company's annual report pointed out:

> The Tinnevelly Riots and the State prosecutions both at Tinnevelly and Tuticorin had a discouraging effect on the public who unnecessarily persuaded themselves, from a vague sense of fear, that they should not go in for the company's shares and debentures.[73]

The fear was more than 'vague'; it was clear and present. The police not only shadowed the volunteers and canvassers but also kept a tab on those who invested. Subscribing to SSNCo was therefore a double jeopardy: not only was one making a losing investment, one also came under the radar of the government.[74] The cumulative effect of the state's intimidatory actions was that it depressed prospective investors even though many of them looked to buy shares often in a show of patriotism rather than for dividends. 'It is too much to ask our people, naturally timid in investing their money on enterprises,' noted *The Hindu*, 'not to get afraid of investing their money on this Swadeshi enterprise, and shareholders from whom arrears were due were frequently heard to request their names to be removed from the list of shareholders, lest warrants might issue against them also'.[75] In Bodinayakanur, volunteers found it difficult to raise shares for the company.[76] On a canvassing tour in Guntur, when Somasundara Bharati greeted his audience with the cry of Vande Mataram, there was no response. Interpreting this, the reporting CID sub-inspector said, 'This shows how far people are afraid to utter these words.'[77]